

Bombas

In 2011, David Heath learned that socks were the number one item requested by people experiencing homelessness. He realized he could help, and he started carrying socks in his bag and handing them out to unhoused individuals he encountered on his way to work.

Heath didn't initially see this as a business opportunity—it's not easy to earn money by donating a product—but he wondered whether he could address this need on a larger, more sustainable scale. He and his friend, and eventual cofounder, Randy Goldberg, began spending their after-work hours researching socks as well as branding and financing, and they realized that if they could sell socks at a high enough price, they could donate a pair for each pair sold. They landed on the name *Bombas*—Latin for bumblebees—to reflect how bees work together to improve their hive.

Heath and Goldberg soon launched a crowdfunding¹ campaign: “BOMBAS: Better Socks. Better world. Bee Better.” In 30 days, they brought in \$150,000 of startup funds. By 2013, their idea had turned into a sock company with a vision: “Buy One...Donate One.”

From Concept to Reality: Product, Price, and Customers

Once the idea was formed, Heath and Goldberg spent more than two years conducting market and technical research before they were ready to launch. They discovered there were two main categories of socks for everyday use: basic socks that sold for as low as \$1 a pair and performance socks for specific sports, such as hiking or running, that sold for as much as \$30 a pair. There was a gap in the market: high quality, comfortable socks for everyday use.

Finding a way to meet that need could be a game-changer. They knew that they could initially appeal to a customer's desire to give back and to help the less fortunate, but they needed to find a way to keep customers coming back to make the business sustainable. A premium sock was the answer.

Heath started wearing high-end socks and noting the features that made them better, such as a honeycomb arch for increased support, merino wool for comfort and endurance, and a toe designed without a toe seam to minimize chafing. “Our goal was to create the most comfortable socks in the history of feet” (Mainwaring 2020).

Heath and Goldberg met with experts in the fashion and manufacturing industries to design the socks and develop a production process. The socks evolved through a testing and iteration process that involved the founders wearing each version of the socks and providing them free to random people they met in exchange for candid feedback. Figure 1 shows the final sock design and packaging.

¹ Crowdfunding is gathering small donations or investment funding from a large number of people to fund an activity, such as a new business idea.



Figure 1. Bombas socks
Keith Homan / Shutterstock.com

Heath and Goldberg knew a second key to success would be pricing. Bombas needed to price its socks high enough that the amount paid by a customer would cover the cost of producing two

pairs of socks—the ones sold and the ones given away—and still provide profits to the company.

If customers were just looking for socks, they wouldn't pay such high prices. So Bombas had to target a specific customer—one with the disposable income to pay \$13 to \$20 for a pair of socks and a desire to help others.

In the beginning, they targeted millennials, “the ones who care about the planet, and sustainability, and giving back,” Heath said, but by 2023, they realized Bombas sold well to a wide variety of ages. “The truth of the matter is, we survey our customer base and we’ve got a large customer base over 50. We’ve got customers in their 40s, in their 30s...everybody validates for us that the reason that they chose and still choose to support Bombas is because we’re a brand that does good.” (Chen 2023)

Bombas created specific targets for the company (e.g., one million pairs of socks given away) and publicized these goals to generate more attention. When they donated their one millionth pair of socks—a goal they expected would take 10 years but only took two and a half years—founder David Heath made good on his promise to get a tattoo of the company logo and slogan ‘bee better’ on his arm. He even posted a video of himself getting the tattoo, furthering his connection to his customer base by celebrating the milestone together.

Bombas became known as the most successful (by revenue) business to pitch on ABC’s Shark Tank, and the business has earned a variety of accolades, including NBC’s 2024 Wellness Award.

By 2024, Bombas had expanded into underwear and T-shirts, and they released their first ever shoes, “Friday Slides,” made from lightweight plastic. They have given away over 100 million items of clothing, earned more than \$1 billion in lifetime revenue, and continue to enjoy their reputation for producing high quality, comfortable socks.

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